

Text Structure & Paragraph Function — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 60 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITION

Structure questions ask not what a paragraph says, but what **job** it does in the whole passage.

COMMON PARAGRAPH JOBS — COPY THE LIST

- Setting the scene / establishing context
- Introducing a problem or conflict
- Zooming in (wide view → one small detail)
- Zooming out (one detail → wider significance)
- Shifting time (flashback / flash-forward)
- Shifting focus between characters
- Building tension before a turning point
- Resolving / providing closure

TECHNIQUE — 3 STEPS

1. Summarise each paragraph in 5 words or fewer
2. Ask: how does this paragraph connect to the one before/after it?
3. Name its job using the list above, then explain the effect on the reader

SENTENCE FRAME TO COPY

"This paragraph's job is to _____. It connects to the previous paragraph by _____, and creates _____ for the reader."

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A (3 PARAGRAPHS)

1. The harbour was busy that morning, boats jostling for space at the quay, gulls fighting over scraps from the fish market.
2. Among them, one small blue boat sat unclaimed, its rope looped loosely over the post, no owner in sight.
3. It would be another two days before anyone realised the boat's owner had never come back from his morning trip.

1. What job does paragraph 1 do?

2. How does paragraph 2 narrow the focus compared to paragraph 1?

3. What structural technique is used in paragraph 3 (a jump forward in time)?

4. What effect does ending on paragraph 3's revelation have on the reader?

5. Summarise all 3 paragraphs in 5 words or fewer each.

EXTRACT B (3 PARAGRAPHS)

1. Across the whole country, hedgehog numbers have fallen by half in the last twenty years.

2. In one Yorkshire garden, though, a single hedgehog called Pins has been visiting the same feeding spot every night for three years.

3. Small, individual gardens like this one, campaigners argue, may be the species' best remaining hope.

6. Is paragraph 1 zooming in or zooming out compared to paragraph 2?

7. What job does paragraph 2 do differently from paragraph 1?

8. What job does paragraph 3 do, connecting back to paragraph 1's statistic?

9. Why might a writer choose to move from a big statistic to one small example?

10. Write a one-sentence structural summary of the whole extract.

EXTRACT C (2 PARAGRAPHS)

1. Before the exam, Leila had promised herself she wouldn't check her phone once.

2. Three hours later, phone still face-down in her bag, she realised she genuinely hadn't thought about it once.

11. What time shift happens between paragraph 1 and paragraph 2?

12. What job does paragraph 1 do (setting up an expectation)?

13. What job does paragraph 2 do in relation to paragraph 1's promise?

14. What effect does this before/after structure create?

15. Could the writer have reversed the paragraph order? Explain the effect if so.

EXTRACT D (3 PARAGRAPHS)

1. The rehearsal had gone badly, again.

2. Backstage, nobody spoke. Marcus reset the props without being asked; Priya rewound the same eight bars twice, listening for the mistake.

3. By the final run-through that evening, something had shifted — the mistake was gone, and nobody mentioned it again.

16. What job does paragraph 1 do?

17. What structural technique is used in paragraph 2 (shifting attention between two characters)?

18. What job does paragraph 3 do?

19. What is the overall structure of this extract: problem → response → resolution, or scene → flashback → scene?

20. Explain the effect of "nobody mentioned it again" as a closing line.

Apply this every time: On any "why has the writer structured it this way" question, name the specific job (zoom in, time shift, focus shift, resolution) — never just describe what happens.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

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|--|---|
| 1. Setting the scene | 11. Forward jump (3 hours) |
| 2. Zooms from many boats to one | 12. Sets up expectation/tension |
| 3. Time shift forward | 13. Shows quiet resolution/success |
| 4. Creates unease/foreboding | 14. Understated, satisfying contrast |
| 5. Model 5-word summaries | 15. Reversing would remove suspense |
| 6. Zooming out (wide stat) | 16. Introducing a problem |
| 7. Zooms in to one example | 17. Shifting focus between characters |
| 8. Zooms back out to significance | 18. Resolving/providing closure |
| 9. Makes the issue feel personal/relatable | 19. Problem → response → resolution |
| 10. Model summary | 20. Suggests quiet relief, avoids over-explaining |